Introduction to Claude Cowork

Delegation · Plugins · Scheduling · Research

mostly Opus 4.6

Previously, on Subagents...

Subagents

Separate Claude instances with their own context window, spawned for specific tasks.

Built-in Types

General Purpose (full tools), Explore (fast search), Plan (architecture design).

Custom Agents

Define in `.claude/agents/*.md` with frontmatter: tools, model, isolation, maxTurns.

When to Use

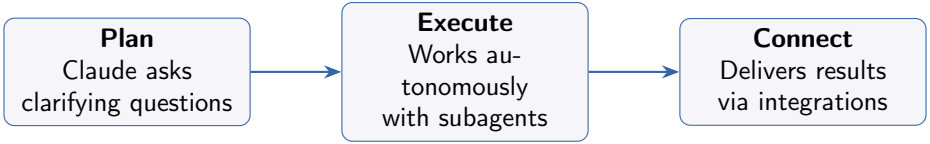
Research, code reviews, parallel work. Avoid for simple tasks or sequential pipelines.

Advanced Features

Background execution, worktree isolation, agent teams for multi-session coordination.

What Is Cowork?

Cowork = Claude's delegation mode in the desktop app.
Instead of conversation, you *hand off* a complete task and step away.



Three modes in Claude desktop:

- **Chat** — conversational back-and-forth
- **Cowork** — delegate and step away
- **Code** — Claude Code in the IDE

Platforms: macOS and Windows (since February 2026).

Getting Set Up

Requirements:

- Claude desktop app
- Folder access configured (grant access to working directories)
- Connectors enabled (Google Drive, Notion, Slack, etc.)
- Chrome extension (optional, for web tasks)

Key difference from Chat

In Cowork, you describe what you want done and *walk away*. Claude will ask clarifying questions only if needed, then execute autonomously.

The Task Loop

1. **Describe** your task clearly
2. **Questions** — Claude may ask for clarification
3. **Step away** — Claude works with subagents in parallel
4. **Open finished work** — review the deliverables

Subagents in Cowork: (see *Subagents* deck)

- Cowork spawns multiple subagents for parallel execution
- Each handles a piece of the overall task
- Results are merged into a coherent deliverable

Example

"Organize all PDFs in my Downloads folder by topic, rename them with a consistent naming scheme, and create a summary index."

Giving Cowork Context

Projects

- Upload reference files to a project
- Claude uses them as knowledge base
- Persistent across tasks

Instructions Panel

- Per-project custom instructions
- Tone, format, conventions

Global Instructions

- Apply to all Cowork tasks
- Your preferences everywhere

In the prompt itself

- Attach files, screenshots
- Reference URLs
- Be specific about desired output

Plugins: Skills + Connectors + Subagents

Plugins bundle capabilities into installable packages:

Skills	Connectors	Subagents
Reusable instructions (see *Agent Skills* deck)	Integrations with external services	Specialized agent definitions

Installation: Browse the plugin directory (growing catalog), install with one click.
Structure:

```
my-plugin/
  skills/
    data-analysis/SKILL.md
  connectors/
    sheets-connector.json
  agents/
    analyst.md
```

Scheduled Tasks & File Operations

Scheduled Tasks (`/schedule`):

- Set up recurring Cowork tasks
- Define cadence (daily, weekly, custom)
- Manage and monitor from the app

File & Document Tasks:

Follow the prompt pattern: **Input** → **Transformation** → **Output**

Examples

- "Take these 20 customer emails, extract feature requests, create a prioritized spreadsheet"
- "Read all markdown files in docs/, fix formatting, add missing headers"
- "Convert this PDF report into a slide deck with key findings"

Research & Analysis at Scale

Cowork excels at **volume, parallelism, and in-place computation**.

Tips for effective research prompts:

- Ask **sharp, specific questions** (not broad/vague)
- Specify the **output format** you want
- Provide **source materials** or point to directories
- Let Cowork parallelize across subagents

Permissions & Model Choice

- Cowork runs in **isolated execution** — controlled access
- Review outputs before acting on them
- Model choice: **Opus** (complex), **Sonnet** (balanced), **Haiku** (fast/cheap)

Computer Use

Claude can control your computer — open apps, navigate browsers, fill forms, click UI elements.

How it works:

1. Grant Claude screen and input access
2. Describe the task (e.g. "book a meeting with Alex on Tuesday")
3. Claude navigates the screen autonomously
4. Review and confirm actions

Use cases

- Fill out forms across multiple tools
- Navigate legacy systems without APIs
- Automate repetitive desktop workflows

Limitations

- macOS primary; Windows support expanding
- Review actions before confirming
- Not suitable for high-stakes inputs

Summary

Key Takeaways

- Cowork = **delegation mode**: describe task, step away, get results
- Task loop: Describe → Clarify → Execute → Deliver
- Context via: projects, instructions panel, global settings, inline
- Plugins bundle skills + connectors + subagents
- `/schedule` for recurring tasks
- File tasks: Input → Transformation → Output pattern
- Computer Use: desktop automation (macOS; review before confirming)
- Research: sharp questions, specified format, parallelized execution

Questions?